THE TRIAGE CARD

Pastoral Triage Card

One page. Photocopy it. It is not a substitute for a trained director, a confessor, or a clinician.

Two questions, always first

1. *"What do you think this practice is doing?"* — reveals the metaphysics.
2. *"If it stopped working tomorrow, what would you do?"* — reveals the god.

Green — affirm and add the frame.

Goal-setting · journalling · gratitude lists · positive self-talk about one's own capacities · habit, sleep and exercise routines from self-help · "manifesting" used loosely for hoping.

Amber — catechesis and a substitute.

Visualization of a desired good · affirmations · vision boards · strong-sense "manifesting" of a job or partner · crystals as aesthetics · astrology as entertainment · loose "energy" talk.

Say: "Almost everything you're doing is fine. The reason you were given for why it works is not, and here is a better one." *Give:* one practice from Part Four, written down, with a time.

Red — renounce, and replace.

Channeling or "higher self" guidance · mediums · attempts to control another's will · "reality shifting" · curses and hexes · telling a sick person she caused her illness · anything requiring secrecy from the Church, a spouse, or a director · any fee for spiritual power.

Say it briefly, without disgust. Then put something in the space.

Six cases in one line each

- **The teenager:** do not take the notebook; change the addressee. Give her a novena.
- **The scrupulous:** thoughts are not creative; temptation is not sin; the first movement is not consent. Repeat. Refer if severe.
- **The grieving:** "That is not true, and it is not what the Church teaches, and I am sorry you were told it." Then sit down.
- **The person in danger:** safety before metaphysics. Refer.
- **The person refusing treatment:** using medicine is not a lack of faith. "Take the medicine, and keep praying." Involve family and doctor the same day.
- **The person with an experience:** test the fruit; be slow; *nihil obstat* is not approval.

The rule about the bedside

No teaching, correction, or catechesis with the dying, the acutely grieving, or the newly diagnosed. Presence only. Say once, if it is true and the moment is right: *you did not do this, and you are not being punished, and God is not disgusted by you.*

What to hand over

- **One practice** — small, timed, written down.
- **One name** — a director, confessor, or chaplain, with a phone number.
- **One sentence** she will remember at 2 a.m.

When to refer

Persistent scrupulosity · intrusive thoughts causing distress · any suggestion of self-harm · suspected abuse · symptoms of psychosis · involvement with a group that demands secrecy or money. Refer to a clinician, a safeguarding officer, or both. This is not a failure of faith.